

Assignment of Topic 1: Philosophical paradox

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Background info: In class, we discussed the question that if there is any knowledge which is so certain that no reasonable man could doubt it. We reached the idea of logic, for example, the proposition of “A or not A”, might be such a knowledge. However, such kind of knowledge was once doubted by René Descartes, imaging an "evil demon" might be manipulating our minds to make us believe the proposition of “A or not A”. René Descartes finally pointed out the famous philosophical statement "I think, therefore I am.", which in this case meant there's one thing that is certain, which is the fact that he was doubting.

My idea: Here, I'd like to challenge René Descartes' idea. There's an assumption of the man is doubting, so that we reach the point where it is certain that the man is doubting. Otherwise, if the man is not doubting, which is possible, it is sure that the man isn't doubting. In the latter case, although the knowledge is not being doubted, which indicates that there is knowledge which is so certain that no reasonable man could doubt it, the indication is based on the premise that it is certain that either a man is doubting or isn't doubting. This premise is correct only when the logic of “A or not A” is true, which still could be doubted through the thought experiment of an "evil demon" manipulating our minds to make us believe the Law of Excluded Middle (“A or not A”) is true. In conclusion, the statement of "I think, therefore I am." might as well be a knowledge that could be doubted.